

Bluff

YOUR WAY THROUGH

Markup Languages

Most of the content you see on the Web exists because markup languages like HTML and XML exist. That you know. But you might not know that this class of languages is not limited to two or three.

DHTML: Dynamic Hyper Text Markup Language can be described as a combination of several technologies like HTML, client-side Java Script, and Cascading Style Sheets. Most of the pages and multimedia content on the Web are created using DHTML. (Very popular.)

XHTML: extensible Hypertext Markup Language. Traditional HTML does not impose much structural strictness, sometimes resulting in poorly-displayed pages. The use of XHTML enables content to be displayed similarly across different browsers. (A good thing.)

VoiceXML: Used in voice interaction between humans and computers, mainly in systems that enable you to, for example, check your credit card balance over the phone. The logic-like dialogue management and speech recognition—is defined by VoiceXML. (Sometimes iffy.)

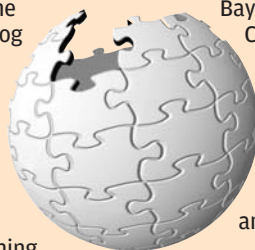
LaTeX: A document markup language used mainly by mathematicians, authors, etc. to typeset their content. It is suitable for representing mathematical formulas. (For the boffins.)

Usage Hey, just looked at your page... Schrödinger wouldn't recognise his equation if he clicked on that link there... you haven't used LaTeX at all! And you know what—use DHTML and XHTML for your page; don't get stuck on HTML, you lazy bum, you. Pages should look nice wherever. Oh, and just BTW, my Amex is maxed out. Two clicks and I knew... somebody finally got their VoiceXML right.

Wild Wild Web

Edit Away (Don't)

You, we, and the neighbour's dog can edit Wikipedia. The People's Encyclopaedia should state, we think: "First, be unbiased." But that's not happening, no. People and groups have been merrily editing the 'pedia without giving two hoots for neutrality. This motivated a geek to create an online scanning tool (www.wikiscanner.virgil.gr) to track edits. Many people already have been caught with their pants down. IPs from the FBI have edited



pages related to Guantanamo Bay. Church groups (for Christ's sake—literally!) have edited out reportage about sex scandals. Visit that site. It's going to get interestinger and interestinger.

Big Mother—And Others

The next time you're about to post a picture of yourself at a beer-drinking contest, think again. And again. Your mom could see it. Reports are in that employers have taken to checking out new recruits' profiles to go beyond what's in their CVS—

and that includes looking at gory details in social networking sites. Now parents have been snooping around their kids' Facebook profiles to find out what misdemeanours junior is up to as well! Momma is never far away, children.

Another potential problem is when the boss sends out friend requests. Poor employees are caught between the devil and the deep sea: ignore the request and get into his sad books, or risk him going through all those scraps or posts that describe how, in George Costanza style, they spiked his drink that time when... The times they have a-changed.

It's just a fabulous piece of machine, and she just had to use it.

Q. Are you serious?

A. We're speculating here, to be perfectly honest.

Q. In this age of paperless communications, why did AT&T not just tell her to pay up the \$200 whatever?

A. They have a policy. Every data transfer has to reflect in a customer's bill. So now you know. It's refreshing to see such red tape outside of India.

Q. What do I gain from all this?

A. Nothing much, just the idea that you shouldn't buy an iPhone. It'll get you hooked to text messaging. In fact, Justine Ezarik had to have her fingers amputated after all this.

Q. Are you kidding me?

A. Yes.

DUPED IN LOVE

Machete, No Marriage

The Internet is a happy hunting ground for conmen. They peddle scams ranging from Nigerian oil bonds to free

iPods and trips to Tahiti. Folks we contemptuously call stupid fall for these, and give out such details as their credit card numbers and whether they like to be whipped during sex. This one scam caught our attention because the man in question almost lost his life. A sad one, this.

A misguided Australian farmer was surfing on the Net and he seems to have hooked up with a chick in, of all places, Mali. (That's somewhere in Africa.) The "lady" was willing to marry, and she also seemed rich, ready with a dowry of gold bars worth \$85,000 (Rs 35 lakh). Not to miss up on the chance, our boy from down under went to Mali to formalise the nuptials. All went well until the prospective

groom found himself shepherded into a room where two machete-wielding goons robbed him of his cash and credit cards, thrashed him, and threatened to hack his limbs off unless he gave them that \$85,000 as the price for his life. Talk about the shoe being on the other foot...

To cut a long story short, the shaken man got off without serious harm when Australian and Malian police lured the kidnappers into the Canadian embassy and arrested them. And escorted the farmer, probably swearing bachelorhood for life, back to Sythe Austrylia. Someone said—in a Dave Barry book—"Look man, I don't trust anybody on the Internet, man! Heck, not my mother! Not even myself!" Now that's a lesson!

